



Antigua-based American billionaire Allen Stanford, who wants to stage an invitational T20 early next year valued at \$20 million. Stanford has invited India, as World T20 winners, to compete for a \$5 million prize against a team of Caribbean Twenty20 All Stars.

But Twenty20 was never invented with global domination in mind. It started with the modest intention of bringing in crowds for domestic cricket in England. Faced with dwindling attendances, the England & Wales Cricket Board decided to reach out to people who were neither die-hard cricket fans nor did they dislike the game. They conducted interviews with 4,000 such "tolerators" in 30 focus groups and what emerged was that cricket-neutrals would choose to watch if it didn't interfere with work and didn't take all day. The first-ever Twenty20 game was staged in June 2003.

T20 competition was first sold as "Twice the action, half the time". As part of the fare on offer, pop bands performed on big game days, the

"I AM STARTING TO NOT SO MUCH LIKE IT AS A PLAYER, BUT LOVE WATCHING IT."

◀ ADAM GILCHRIST,
WICKETKEEPER, AUSTRALIA

sideshows sometimes including skydivers and speed-dating booths. The baseball-style dugouts were introduced to ensure that new batsmen got on to the field in 90 seconds as opposed to the conventional three minutes. Occasionally a member of the fielding side was wired up and talked to commentators when the action was live.

The first game drew a crowd of just under 5,000, but today, a T20 match draws an average crowd of 7,000, close to the capacity of most of England's small county grounds. In 2004, Lord's held 27,500 for a match between Middlesex and Surrey, the biggest attendance at a county match (not a final) at the ground since 1953. It is estimated

GLAMOUR: Dancing cheerleaders were only one part of the razzmatazz that today, the seven T20 games staged by each of the counties every year, earn them more than all the games they host for the rest of the season.

Wherever cricket needed to sustain its domestic game and was in serious competition with other sports for advertisers and spectators, Twenty20 has thrived. Australia has been playing Twenty20 for four seasons now and the 2006-07 final between Victoria and Tasmania attracted 28,000 people—the largest audience for a domestic match in Australia since the World War II. When Pakistan staged its first domestic T20 final, there were as many people outside the Gaddafi Stadium in Lahore trying to get in as there were on the ground watching the game.

In South Africa, the national Pro20 tournament among nine franchises is jam-packed, televised and has introduced an innovation which is bound to catch on in the rest of the world. The players wear heart-rate belts, which